Kiabi — Deep Research Report

Prepared for: Chief Information Officer and CIO Office

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1. Company at a glance

Kiabi is a French value-fashion retailer owned by the Association Familiale Mulliez, founded in Lille in 1978 and headquartered at Kiabi Village in Lezennes, near Lille. It closed 2025 with sales of €2.5 billion excluding VAT — €3 billion including VAT — up 8% on 2024, against a French clothing market that shrank by 1.3%. The group operates around 648 points of contact across 37 countries, roughly 353 of them in France.

Kiabi designs its collections in-house in France and sells through a mix of company-operated stores, affiliated partner stores and e-commerce. Républik Retail and Le Journal des Entreprises reported from the February 2026 results presentation at Kiabi Village that the group employs close to 10,000 people of 83 nationalities and counts 25 million customers worldwide, up from 24 million a year earlier. It remains privately held within the Mulliez family holding, so no financials are filed on an exchange; the figures above come from the company's own annual presentation and the trade press covering it.

The estate is expanding and its ownership mix is changing. Kiabi has said it will open around 50 stores in 2026 across seven new countries including Switzerland, Argentina, North Macedonia and Bulgaria. The first Argentine store, 1,500 square metres over four levels in central Buenos Aires, opened on 11 August 2026 under a local franchise partner, Grupo One, with an ambition of 20 stores in five years. In France, roughly a third of the network is currently partner-operated and the group is targeting 40% within three to four years — a shift that puts more of the store estate outside direct central control.

The brand portfolio has widened well past apparel. Kiabi Home, the home textiles and décor line launched in 2024, is now in every store and given expanded floor space in around twenty French locations, and has been rolled out in Belgium, Spain and Italy. Kitchoun is the children's brand. Ekstract, a sport and wellbeing brand launched on 10 February 2026, is in stores in France, Spain, Belgium, Italy and Portugal and online. A new logo, unveiled internally in December 2025, was designed as a common mark across this brand family rather than a refresh of the apparel brand alone.

Questions to ask on the day:

- What is the split between company-operated and partner-operated stores today, and how does that change what IT has to deliver?
- What share of revenue is online versus in store?
- How much of the 2036 doubling target is expected to come from new brands and services versus core apparel?

2. Strategic direction

The stated strategy is to move from a fashion retailer to an ecosystem of brands and services for families. This came out of Vision 2035, which Kiabi says was built with its workforce, and was restated at the February 2026 results as a ten-year goal to double revenue and headcount by 2036. Patrick Stassi, the group's chief executive, framed the 2025 performance carefully in his February 2026 remarks and again on France Inter: the strategy is working, but the market is difficult and the company is staying humble about it.

E-commerce and the marketplace are the growth engine on the digital side. Kiabi launched its marketplace in France in 2022; as of February 2026 it carries 230 partner brands, extends the range into childcare, toys and footwear, and draws 12 million monthly visitors. The Kiabi app has passed 3 million downloads. Stassi told Républik Retail in December 2025 that the marketplace was starting to show traction internationally as well.

Services are the third pillar and they are being industrialised rather than piloted. Second-hand is the clearest case. After acquiring the children's resale platform Beebs in 2024 and discontinuing the standalone Kidkanaï store concept in summer 2024, Kiabi brought garment collection in-house under the Beebs by Kiabi brand. Ouarda Ech-Chykry, managing director of Kiabi France, told Républik Retail in February 2026 that every company-operated store was collecting by the start of 2026, with affiliated partners following in the first half of the year, and that Belgium, Spain and Portugal come next. The paid extension of the En Famille loyalty programme is reported to be running ahead of expectations. A new store concept, Kolors, tested in 14 locations between 2023 and 2025, enters phased rollout from 2026.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which of the new brands and services carry the heaviest systems dependency, and which are running on workarounds today?
- What does the marketplace need from IT to scale internationally the way it has in France?
- How is the 2036 plan translated into an IT roadmap, and over what horizon is that roadmap actually planned?

3. Industry forces

Value fashion is the one part of the European clothing market currently working. The French clothing market fell around 1.3% in 2025 by the Institut Français de la Mode's measure, while Kiabi grew 8%. That divergence is the useful frame for the conversation: Kiabi is taking share in a shrinking market rather than riding a recovery, which raises the stakes on execution and makes systems constraints more visible than they would be in a rising market.

Competitive pressure comes from two directions at once. Ultra-fast-fashion platforms compete on price and assortment velocity, and Shein's move into physical French retail through department stores in late 2025 showed that the boundary between the two models is not stable. At the same time the established European chains — Inditex, H&M, Primark, Mango — are all putting money into technology and omnichannel infrastructure, which is where the differentiation now sits.

AI has moved from experiment to operating expectation across the sector during 2026. Inditex said in its first-quarter 2026 statement that artificial intelligence is increasingly embedded across group operations. Zalando reported ten million customers using its AI assistant in the first quarter of 2026 and robots automating two million picks a month. The practical question for a CIO is less whether to adopt and more how to get data into a state where adoption produces measurable results.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Where is competitive pressure actually showing up in your systems — pricing, assortment speed, delivery promise, or customer data?
- What has changed in the last twelve months about how the business asks IT for things?

4. Regulatory and compliance frame

Three EU instruments now bear directly on Kiabi's operations, and one of them is already live. Under the Ecodesign for Sustainable Products Regulation, large companies have been prohibited from destroying unsold apparel, clothing accessories and footwear since 19 July 2026. The European Commission adopted the delegated and implementing regulations setting out the permitted derogations on 9 February 2026; where destruction does occur under an exception, companies must document the justification and notify the waste treatment operator. Large companies are already subject to disclosure obligations on discarded unsold products, and a standardised reporting format applies from February 2027. This is a systems requirement as much as a policy one: it needs unsold-stock volumes, weights, reasons and disposal routes to be traceable through to reporting.

The revised Waste Framework Directive, Directive (EU) 2025/1892, entered into force on 16 October 2025 and makes extended producer responsibility schemes for textiles mandatory across every member state, with national schemes required to be operational by around April 2028. France has had Refashion in place since 2007, so the immediate work is in Kiabi's other markets, and fees will be eco-modulated against durability, repairability and recyclability — meaning the fee depends on product-level data the company will have to hold and defend.

Sustainability reporting scope changed materially in 2026. The Omnibus I Directive, Directive (EU) 2026/470, entered into force on 18 March 2026 and raised the CSRD threshold to companies with more than 1,000 employees and more than €450 million in net turnover, applying to financial years beginning on or after 1 January 2027. Kiabi is comfortably above both thresholds and remains in scope, so the reprieve that removed an estimated 80% of companies from CSRD does not apply here.

France's anti-fast-fashion law, law number 2026-602, was finally adopted on 29 June 2026 and promulgated on 8 July 2026. The final text narrowed to ultra-express fashion and largely spares European chains including Kiabi from the per-item penalty, which starts at up to €12 in 2026 and rises to €20 by 2030 for those in scope. The advertising ban takes effect on 1 January 2027 and implementing decrees are still to come. Separately, Stassi said in February 2026 that around 75% of Kiabi garments already carry an eco-score and that the target is 100% of products by the end of 2026, describing the remaining work as technically involved.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Who owns the unsold-stock disclosure data end to end, and which system is the source of record?
- What does eco-modulated EPR fee calculation require from your product data that you don't hold today?
- What is the plan for CSRD data collection ahead of the FY2027 first reporting year?
- What did getting from 75% to 100% eco-score coverage turn out to actually depend on?

5. The CIO's world at Kiabi

Christophe Alié holds the combined role of Leader Innovation and Transformation and Chief Information Officer, and has been with Kiabi for around a quarter of a century, including a long run leading the information system for Kiabi Europe before transformation was added to the remit. He has spoken publicly about running transformation on a decade-long horizon, using OKRs to break long-range goals into shorter cycles, and about treating the information system as the instrument of company-wide transformation rather than a support function. The combined title matters: the CIO office here is expected to own change, not just infrastructure.

Two recent public accounts from inside the company give an unusually direct view of the current estate. On payments, Xavier Fouré, Head of International Payments, told Républik Retail in June 2026 that the legacy payment back-office was an accumulation of components originally built for stores and no longer fit for digital volumes, with data split across several tools, teams navigating between platforms to analyse transactions, and significant manual work. Accounting reconciliation alone occupied two people close to full time. Kiabi ran a tender at the end of 2024, chose Purse as an orchestration layer over its payment service providers, and began putting flows into production from autumn 2025, targeting seven of its 37 countries in the first phase.

The results reported are specific. Bringing customer identity together with payment — social login and passwordless authentication — cut customer login time by 70% and lifted account-creation conversion by more than 20%. Analysing bank refusal codes through the consolidated view added two to three points of payment acceptance, taking the rate to around 94%. Fouré's framing is worth carrying into the room: acceptance rate is the number he treats as revenue, and identity, payment and fraud are one data problem rather than three.

On data and AI, Julie Huguet-Macquart, Group CRM Leader, described at the Connect Lille forum on 30 June and 1 July 2026 a beta of Splio's Ask My CRM agent connected to Kiabi's CRM data. The team rebuilt a four-week sales campaign plan in about thirty minutes, work that previously took days. The more telling detail is what it replaced: previously, getting an analysis meant queueing through the data analysts' prioritisation process and coordinating with product and customer-knowledge teams, and answers often arrived after they had stopped being useful. Kiabi has been using Splio's Tinyclues deep-learning models for around five years, so trust in the algorithms was not the obstacle; learning to ask better questions was. Access has since been extended to customer-knowledge teams. Commercial impact has not yet been measured — it is still a beta.

Questions to ask on the day:

- What are your KPIs, and which of them are you actually held to at executive level?
- How is the IT organisation split across operations, digital, data and security, and how does that map onto 37 countries?
- The payment programme covers seven countries in phase one — what determines the sequence for the rest?
- Where else in the business does the pattern from CRM repeat, where the answer arrives after the decision?

6. Peer signals

H&M has shifted the balance of its investment. At its 2025 results presentation in February 2026 the group said spending would go mainly to the store portfolio and technology infrastructure, with logistics investment coming down. The CFO drew an explicit parallel to the 2018–2019 online platform build, framing this as the next foundational technology cycle rather than incremental improvement.

Inditex reported 2025 sales of €39.9 billion with online at €10.7 billion, and guided to around €2.3 billion of ordinary capital expenditure in 2026 directed mainly at optimising commercial space, technological integration and improving online platforms. It has continued rolling out soft-tag RFID technology across Zara stores and invested in AI-driven logistics automation.

Zalando has turned its own infrastructure into a product. ZEOS, its logistics and returns operating system, now enables around €11 billion of GMV for more than 1,200 partners including Marks & Spencer, Pepe Jeans and NEXT, alongside SCAYLE for storefronts and Tradebyte for marketplace integration. Group GMV reached €17.56 billion in 2025. It is simultaneously consolidating its network after the ABOUT YOU integration, closing its Erfurt fulfilment centre by the end of September 2026 to leave 14 centres across seven countries.

Primark, long the holdout, has moved further than the standard account suggests. Click and collect is now live in all 189 UK stores, and on 9 April 2026 Primark launched its first UK customer app, following equivalent launches in Ireland and Italy, combining real-time stock checks, notifications, favourites and click-and-collect. Around a quarter of UK website visitors use the stock check feature. The company has publicly reiterated that it is still not doing home delivery — a deliberate choice about which parts of digital pay back.

Mango is the closest peer on AI-for-personalisation. Its generative AI assistant Mango Stylist runs in nine markets including France, integrated with its after-sales assistant Iris to give one conversational point of contact across the journey. Mango says it has built more than fifteen machine-learning platforms since 2018 covering pricing, design, personalisation and customer service, under the Earn pillar of its 2024–2026 strategic plan.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Are you benchmarking against any of these programmes specifically, and which ones does the business raise with you?
- Zalando has made its infrastructure a revenue line — is anything in Kiabi's stack a candidate for that?
- Primark's decision to do click-and-collect but not delivery is a systems-scope decision as much as a commercial one. What equivalent lines have you drawn?

7. Friction map

The two published accounts from inside Kiabi describe the same shape of problem from different corners of the business. In payments, information about a single transaction sat across several tools, so building a consolidated view meant moving between platforms and doing part of the work by hand; two people were effectively employed on reconciliation. In CRM, the data existed in quantity — purchases, omnichannel journeys, in-store behaviour, digital interactions, communication preferences — but converting it into a decision required going through a prioritisation queue, and the answer frequently arrived too late to act on.

Both were addressed by putting a layer over the fragmentation rather than by consolidating the underlying systems: an orchestration platform in payments, a conversational agent in CRM. That is a pragmatic pattern and it produced measurable results quickly, but it leaves the question of what happens to the layers underneath, and how many more such layers the estate can carry.

Two structural factors make this harder here than the headline numbers suggest. Thirty-seven countries with different payment habits, languages and legal requirements means anything built centrally needs local variation. And a French estate moving from around a third to 40% partner-operated means a growing share of stores sits outside direct operational control, which complicates rollout, data collection and anything requiring uniform execution — including second-hand collection and eco-score coverage.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which processes still consume the most manual effort, and where is the next reconciliation problem hiding?
- After payments and CRM, is the intent to keep adding orchestration layers or to consolidate underneath?
- What breaks first when a central initiative meets a partner-operated store or a smaller market?

Challenge cards

Card 1 of 2

Company: Kiabi

Theme: Fragmented estate, payments and finance reconciliation

Challenge: Building the view by hand

The challenge: Payment and accounting information was spread across several systems built at different times for different purposes. To understand a transaction or reconcile the accounts, teams had to move between platforms and manually assemble a complete view. In payments this meant two people working close to full time on accounting reconciliation, while analysts navigated multiple tools to investigate individual transactions.

Who feels it: Payment operations and finance teams performing the manual investigation and reconciliation; technology and data teams supporting the connections between systems; and business functions waiting for trusted transaction, payment-acceptance and revenue information.

Why it persists: Kiabi's technology estate grew component by component as the business expanded across stores, digital channels and countries. Store-era systems now carry digital-era transaction volumes, while newer tools have been added around them. Each addition addressed a specific need, but collectively they fragmented the transaction view. Replacing the foundations is a larger commitment than adding a consolidating layer.

What solved looks like: Payment, finance and IT teams access the same trusted transaction data through one entry point, with transaction status, refusal codes and reconciliation exceptions visible without manual assembly. Kiabi has introduced this for payments through the Purse orchestration layer, improving payment acceptance and enabling reconciliation staff to move to higher-value work.

Evidence base: Xavier Fouré, Head of International Payments, described the legacy payment back office, fragmented data and reconciliation burden to Républik Retail in June 2026. He also outlined the tender launched at the end of 2024 and the phased introduction of Purse from autumn 2025.

Open question: Where else across Kiabi are teams still manually assembling information from multiple systems to create a trusted view, and should these gaps be addressed through additional orchestration layers or by consolidating the underlying technology estate?

Card 2 of 2

Company: Kiabi

Theme: Analytics latency, self-serve customer data

Challenge: The answer arrives after the decision

The challenge: CRM and marketing teams depended on specialist data analysts to turn customer data into usable insights. Each request entered a prioritisation queue and required coordination across data, product and customer-knowledge teams. By the time the analysis was delivered, the campaign or business decision had sometimes already passed. The data existed, but teams could not access answers at the speed decisions were being made.

Who feels it: CRM and marketing teams waiting for campaign insights; data analysts managing a growing queue of requests; customer-knowledge and product teams supporting the analysis; and business owners making time-sensitive decisions without the evidence they had requested.

Why it persists: Customer data is distributed across purchases, omnichannel journeys, in-store behaviour, digital interactions and communication preferences. Turning this data into an answer required specialist analytical skills concentrated within a small team. As demand for customer insight increased, the volume of requests grew faster than the specialist team's capacity to respond.

What solved looks like: Business teams can ask questions directly of governed CRM data, receive answers quickly and move from analysis to recommended actions. Kiabi is testing this through an agent connected to its CRM data. A four-week sales campaign plan was rebuilt in around thirty minutes, and the agent identified relevant customer categories the team had not initially considered.

Evidence base: Julie Huguet-Macquart, Group CRM Leader, presented the CRM agent beta at the Connect Lille forum on 30 June and 1 July 2026, as reported by Républik Retail. She noted that the beta is recent, its commercial impact has not yet been measured, and access has been extended to customer-knowledge teams.

Open question: Where else are time-sensitive business decisions delayed by dependence on specialist analysis, and could governed self-service access support areas such as forecasting and replenishment without compromising data quality, security or accountability?

Where this document is thin

- The size, structure and budget of Kiabi's IT organisation are not public.
- Christophe Alié's current title and scope rest on sources from mid-2025 and should be confirmed before the meeting.
- No IT-specific KPIs or targets for the CIO office are publicly stated.
- The current e-commerce, ERP and marketplace platform stack is not documented recently; the 2022 marketplace launch partners are the last public record.
- Kiabi's cloud arrangements were last reported publicly in 2021 and nothing current confirms what runs where today.
- The online share of total revenue is not disclosed; the company reports digital growth in double digits without giving the base.
- No security incident, breach or regulatory enforcement action involving Kiabi was found in public sources, which is not the same as none having occurred.
- How the CIO office is structured against 37 country operations, and how much authority sits locally, is unknown.
- The systems implications of moving the French estate toward 40% partner-operated have not been publicly discussed.
- Kiabi's readiness for CSRD first reporting on FY2027, and who owns it, is not documented.
- Nothing public describes how second-hand collection, eco-score data and unsold-stock disclosure are handled in systems terms — three separate regulatory data flows that may or may not share a foundation.